

Hausmann's Paris

In 1853, Emperor Napoleon III (1808–73) made lawyer Georges-Eugène Haussmann (1809–91) Prefect of the Seine Department, and he began renovating the unhealthy, congested streets of Paris. In 1850, most of the city was still as it was in the medieval period, with narrow, winding streets and open sewers, but its population had doubled since 1800 to over one million. The severe overcrowding bred disease and unrest, and the streets were confusing and congested. Haussmann demolished slums and designed a new, airy, open city of gaslit streets. Although he had no previous experience as an architect or an urban planner, he hired tens of thousands of workers to improve the city's sanitation, water supply and traffic circulation, and build wide avenues, parks and squares, sewers, fountains and aqueducts. Paris was divided into *arrondissements* (municipal districts), and many of the straight, wide boulevards intentionally created vistas of monuments or monumental buildings, such as the Arc de Triomphe and the Opéra, while buildings also had new, uniform façades.

